caves in the Tora Bora mountains on Afghanistan's side of the border with Pakistan.

In December 1843 Fergusson read his paper, 'On the rock-cut temples of India', at a meeting of the Royal Asiatic Society in London. This was a genuinely ground-breaking work of art history, first printed in the Society's *Journal* and then republished in 1845 with nineteen lithographic plates to illustrate the text (see illustration). Fergusson showed that rock-cut caves were an integral feature of early Buddhism and, to a lesser extent, early Jainism.

The practice had begun with ascetics of every persuasion making use of natural rock-shelters in the hills for their rainy-season retreats. Then in Emperor Ashoka's time his royal patronage had enabled communities of Buddhist, Jain and Ajivika ascetics to employ masons to cut out custom-built caves in Magadha (now Bihar). At first these were no more than square cells, but with each generation the rock-cutting of the Buddhist community had become ever more ambitious. 'All the Buddhist caves we know of belong to one of two classes,' wrote Fergusson.

> They are either *Viharas* or monasteries, or they are *Chaitya* caves or churches … The oldest *Viharas* consist of one cell only. In the next stage they are extended to a long verandah, with one long cell behind it … In the third, and by far the most numerous class, the cell expands into a hall, generally with pillars in the centre, and around these the cells of the monks are arranged … In ancient times, no sculptures or images were introduced into the *Vihara*, but as early, certainly, as the first or second century of our era we find a chapel always facing the principal entrance and in it we find an image of Buddha … In the *Viharas*, we can trace the progress from the simple cave to the perfect monastery.